



**ROUTEUP CAREER GUIDANCE SERIES — VOLUME 1**

# **Making Informed Decisions About Studying Abroad**

A Practical Guide for Students and Parents

Prepared following the RouteUp Career Guidance July 2026

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# Welcome Message

Dear Attendee,

Greetings from RouteUp, and thank you for taking the time to participate in our Career Guidance Webinar.

Choosing to study abroad is one of the most important decisions a student and their family will ever make. It is not simply about selecting a university or obtaining a visa — it is about building a meaningful career, making sound financial decisions, and creating long-term opportunities.

This guide has been prepared following the webinar as a structured reference for students and parents. It expands on the topics discussed during the session — including the practical figures and real cases shared live — and is intended to help you evaluate your options carefully before making any commitments.

**Our objective is not to encourage every student to study abroad.** Our objective is to help every student make the right decision based on their academic background, career aspirations, financial circumstances, and personal goals.

We hope this document helps you choose with confidence and clarity.

— Team RouteUp

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## 1. Studying Abroad Is a Career Decision, Not Just an Education Decision

Many students begin their overseas journey with a single thought: **“I want to go abroad.”** That should never be the starting point.

The right starting question is: **“What career do I want to build over the next 10 to 20 years?”**

Your choice of country, university, and course should serve that long-term ambition — not simply provide a temporary opportunity to be overseas. Selecting a course without considering future employment prospects leads to career dissatisfaction, financial pressure, and difficulty finding relevant work after graduation.

*“Thousands of people choose the education path only because it looks like the easy entry. Study, then post-study work visa, then hope. Hope is not a plan — the plan starts with the career, and the course follows it.” — from the webinar*

## 2. Choose a Course That Matches Your Academic Background

One of the most common — and most damaging — mistakes is switching into a completely unrelated field because a course looks popular or is being heavily promoted.

This causes two distinct problems:

- **In the job market:** students who studied one discipline and switch to an unrelated one often struggle to compete for jobs in either field — employers see an inconsistent profile with no depth.
- **At immigration stage:** in several countries, immigration officers examine your study history at permanent residency stage. An unexplained switch between unrelated courses is treated as a red flag and can invite difficult questions precisely when the outcome matters most.

Whenever possible: build upon your previous qualifications, choose courses that complement your existing knowledge, and prefer industries with genuine long-term demand over temporary trends. A

consistent academic pathway demonstrates commitment and professional direction — to employers and to immigration authorities alike.

### 3. Avoid Comparing Your Journey with Others

Social media has created unrealistic expectations about studying abroad. Students compare themselves with photographs, reels, and success stories without seeing the full reality behind them — the debts, the struggles, the compromises that never make it into the video.

Be especially careful with influencer content. A reel that says “this is the path” is entertainment, not advice: the person making it does not know your finances, your academics, or your goals — and often earns money when you follow their link.

Every student's situation is different. Financial capacity, academic performance, English ability, career goals, family circumstances, and immigration policy all differ from person to person. Base your decision on research, not comparison.

### 4. Four Questions Every Student Must Ask Before Choosing a Country

#### Question 1 — Can I get in?

Can you realistically obtain admission and the required visa? Check university requirements and official visa criteria on government and university websites — not on social media, and not from an agent's brochure.

#### Question 2 — Can I stay long-term?

Think beyond graduation. Does your profession have sustainable demand in that country? Does a realistic pathway exist from study to work to settlement? Remember from Section 2: course-switching along the way can jeopardise this pathway.

#### Question 3 — What will I earn compared with what it costs to live there?

Do not calculate tuition fees alone. Account for accommodation, food, transport, utilities, internet, insurance, and emergency expenses — the full weekly cost of being alive in that country. Section 5 shows real figures.

#### Question 4 — Will I genuinely be happy there?

Success is not measured only by obtaining a visa. Your wellbeing, safety, work-life balance, and mental health matter. Happiness abroad usually follows from two things: choosing the right course for the right reasons, and not being financially or personally dependent on anyone else after arrival.

### 5. Understand the Reality of Living Costs

Living costs are where most plans quietly fail. Real examples discussed in the session:

- **Australia:** expect around A\$250 per week for accommodation — and that applies even to shared rooms and hostels in major cities, not only private housing.
- **Rent cycles:** in Australia and New Zealand, rent is typically paid weekly, not monthly. Landlords will not wait a month for payment. Budgeting monthly, as we do in India, will mislead you.
- **The full picture:** on top of rent come internet, mobile, transport, groceries, and health insurance — costs that consultancies rarely mention when they hand you a university list.

*“A week can cost close to a thousand dollars before you have done anything special. Nobody shows you that in the brochure — they show you the university gate.” — from the webinar*

Before leaving India, prepare a realistic budget on a daily, weekly, and monthly basis, covering the entire duration of your course. Financial planning is as important as academic planning.

## 6. Do Not Assume You Will Secure a Part-Time Job Immediately

The most dangerous sentence in study-abroad planning is: **“I will find a part-time job as soon as I arrive.”**

Part-time work exists — but no consultant, institution, friend, or relative can guarantee you a job after arrival. Competition varies by city, industry, and season. In the current market, graduates in several destination countries — including the UK and Australia — are struggling to find even survival jobs; many educated migrants end up in delivery, driving, or pharmacy shift work that has nothing to do with their degree.

**The test to apply:** if your ability to continue your education depends on finding part-time work, you are not financially ready to travel yet. A part-time job should strengthen your position — never determine whether you can eat, pay rent, or complete your course.

Ask the uncomfortable question before you fly: **“If I find no part-time work for an entire year, can I still finish my course?”** If the answer is no, revisit your plan — and remember the pressure this places on your parents back home.

## 7. Protect Yourself from False Promises

Be cautious of anyone who promises guaranteed jobs, guaranteed permanent residency, guaranteed visas, or guaranteed migration outcomes. **No ethical adviser can honestly guarantee any of these results.** Visa decisions belong to governments; job offers belong to employers; nobody in between controls either.

A pattern reported to us repeatedly: a consultancy promises “once you arrive, call us — we will arrange your part-time job.” After arrival, the calls go unanswered. The promise cost nothing to make and everything to believe.

Avoid paying any individual who claims they can arrange employment or accommodation without proper verification. Rely on official recruitment processes and established accommodation providers.

### A note on personal safety

This is uncomfortable but necessary. When students — particularly young women — arrive alone and ask strangers from their own community for help with jobs or housing, some of those “helpers” attempt to take advantage of the situation. Cases of this kind are real and are reported to us directly.

- Use your university's official student support services, accommodation office, and international student association first — that is what they exist for.
- Be careful about owing personal favours to individuals you barely know; legitimate help never comes with conditions attached.
- If someone's “help” makes you uncomfortable, stop contact and report it — to the university, and to police if appropriate. You will not be the first to report them.

## 8. Build Your Career Professionally

Finding a job abroad requires method, not luck. Practical guidance from the session:

- **Do not outsource your job search to relatives:** depending on “my brother is there, he will refer me” or “my friend will help” is the weakest possible job strategy. References help, but they are not a plan.

- **LinkedIn cold messaging rarely works:** mass connection requests and copy-paste cold messages are recognised instantly and ignored. Recruiters receive hundreds of them.
- **Email the person who actually hires:** research the organisation, find the hiring manager or recruiter on the company website, and write a short, personalised email with a tailored CV attached. A well-researched email to the right person outperforms fifty generic applications.
- **Understand the screening reality:** as an international applicant, your CV passes through multi-stage screening that local candidates may not face. Expect it, prepare for it, and make sure your CV matches both your academic profile and the specific role.
- **Choose the right roles:** applying to every open position regardless of fit does not increase your chances — it dilutes them. Apply narrowly and deeply, not widely and shallowly.

Meaningful professional relationships are built through genuine engagement and well-prepared applications — real connections, not collection of online contacts.

## 9. Education Loans Should Be Planned Carefully

An education loan is a long-term financial commitment that outlives the excitement of departure.

*“If you take a ₹40 lakh education loan today and repay it over 15 years, the total repayment can approach ₹1 crore. Know that number before you sign — not after.” — from the webinar*

Before accepting any loan, understand: the total repayment amount (not just the principal), the interest structure, the repayment period, your realistic expected salary after graduation, and the return on investment of the specific course in the specific country. Borrow only what your long-term earning capacity — not your optimism — can support.

## 10. Always Have a Plan B

Life does not always go according to plan. Before departure, write down your answers to these questions:

- What if my visa is delayed?
- What if I cannot find part-time work for six months — or a year?
- What if I discover my chosen course is not right for me?
- What if my family's financial situation changes?

Most students travel with Plan A only, because Plan A is the only story anyone sold them. Preparing alternatives is not pessimism — it reduces stress, protects your family, and improves every decision you make under pressure.

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## RouteUp's Commitment

RouteUp was established with one objective: **to help students make informed decisions through honest guidance.** We believe students deserve accurate information, realistic expectations, and practical advice before investing significant time and money in international education.

Our role is not to make decisions for students. Our role is to provide the knowledge that allows students and parents to make those decisions confidently.

## Final Thoughts

Studying abroad can be a life-changing opportunity when approached with careful planning, realistic expectations, and a clear career objective. Do not allow pressure from friends, social media, or unrealistic promises to shape one of the most important decisions of your life.

**Research thoroughly. Plan carefully. Ask questions. Make informed choices. Build your future one decision at a time.**

## Closing Message

Dear Attendee,

Thank you once again for participating in the RouteUp Career Guidance Webinar. We hope the knowledge shared during the session and within this guide assists you in making thoughtful and informed decisions about your future.

Remember: success is not determined by the country you choose. It is determined by the preparation, effort, and decisions you make along the way.

On behalf of everyone at RouteUp, we sincerely wish you every success in your academic and professional journey.

**Choose wisely. Stay informed. Build your future with confidence.**

With warm regards,

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